Aston University
BIRMINGHAM UK

TUITION FEE CHARGING POLICY 2026/27

This document sets out the University's approach to the charging of tuition fees and the sanctions in the event of non-payment.

Version	1
Executive Sponsor	Executive Director of Finance
Officer Responsible for Policy/ Procedures	Deputy Director – Financial Services
Consultation Process	Finance Academic and Student Services Legal Services
Date of Approval and Committee and/or Executive Officer	Executive
Effective Date	1st August 2025

1. SCOPE OF THE POLICY

1.1 Purpose of the Policy.

The purpose of this Policy is to ensure the correct and lawful treatment of students with respect to payment of tuition fees.

1.2 What is covered by the Policy?

This Policy sets out:

- The basis on which students will be charged for tuition fees and their liability at each stage of the academic year if they withdraw or take leave of absence; and
- the sanctions associated with any non-payment of tuition fees.

1.3 Who is covered by the Policy?

All those who undertake a role relating to the payment of tuition fees at the University, including staff, must be aware of and comply with the Policy.

1.4 Breach of this Policy.

Any breach of this Policy and its associated procedures by staff will be investigated in accordance with the University's disciplinary procedure. Any breach of this Policy and its associated procedures by non-staff will be investigated and steps taken in accordance with the law and any relevant contract.

1.5 Policy Ownership.

The Executive has approved this Policy, the Executive Director of Finance is the Executive sponsor, and the Head of Financial Operations is the officer responsible for the Policy. Any questions about the operation of this Policy or any concerns that the Policy has not been followed should be referred in the first instance to the Head of Financial Operations.

2. THE POLICY STATEMENT

2.1 Guiding Principles

The guiding principles of this Policy are that the University will act lawfully and in a fair and transparent manner in relation to the fee charging and always in accordance with Policy.

2.2 Procedures

The following procedures implement this Policy:

- The Debt Management Procedures for Students

3. GLOSSARY OF TERMS

The terms set out in this section 3 apply to this Policy.

Academic year: a 12-month period which begins on 1st August and ends on the 31st of July in the following year.

Academic cycle: The anniversary of the commencement of the programme studied.

Full continuation fee: the continuation fee payable by the student as notified by the University in the student's offer letter from the University.

Full tuition fee for the academic year: the tuition fee payable by the student as stated in the student's offer letter from the University.

Full writing up fee: the tuition fee payable by the student during the writing up period of the programme as stated in the student's offer letter from the University.

Repeat fees: the fee payable by the student for repeating modules.

Home student: The rules about qualifying as a home student depend on nationality, the immigration status of you and your family members and where you have all been living. This is a student who qualifies to be considered for a tuition fee loan and grants and loans for living costs from the UK government.

Initial period: That period, defined for each category of student in section 4 of this policy, after the beginning of each term, or for Aston Online Students the cooling off period, during which a refund of deposit or fees paid may be available The start date of each term can be found at About | Aston University. For the purposes of this policy, the beginning of the first term, for both new and returning students, will be deemed to begin on the date listed as the 'First Term Start Date for Returning Students'.

Leave of absence: This is when a student stops their studies for a period (normally longer than 60 days) for reasons such as illness. An application to take leave of absence must be formally approved by the relevant College of study

For **Aston Online students only,** applications for a Leave of Absence must be made to the Student Success Team via e mail to enquiries@studyonline.com.

Overseas student: This is a student who is a non-UK national who does not meet any of the other eligibility criteria to pay 'home' fees. Overseas students will not be eligible for loans from the UK Government and will need to pay for their own tuition fees and living costs in the UK.

Term: Portions of the Academic year specified on the University website.

Withdrawal: A student may apply to withdraw from their programme at any time and requests to do so must be made through MAP. An application to withdraw from a programme of study has been formally approved when it has been considered by the relevant College of study and a final decision has been made. The status of the request in the MAP task at this stage will normally show as "Request approved and processed by academic College."

For **Aston Online students only,** applications to withdraw from the programme must be made to the Student Success Team via e mail to enquiries@studyonline.com.

4. PRINCIPLES

Unless otherwise stated in this section of this policy, the Initial Period is seven calendar days after the beginning of each term. Students should note that if the Cancellation Period under their Contract has not yet expired in relation to acceptance of their offer, the provisions of their Contract will apply.

More information on the circumstances in which refunds will be considered are set out in section 6.

The University must comply with the following principles in relation to tuition fee charging:

4.1 For Undergraduate students

a) A student will not be liable to pay tuition fees if the student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy within the initial period (see above).
b) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period one (but after the initial period has passed) and within the initial period of teaching period two, the student will be responsible to pay twenty-five per cent (25%) of the full tuition fee for the academic year.
c) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period two (but after the initial period has passed) and within the initial period of teaching period three, the student will be responsible to pay fifty per cent (50%) of the full tuition fee for the academic year.
d) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period three (but after the initial period has passed), the student will be responsible to pay the full tuition fee (100%) for the academic year.
e) Where a student has to repeat modules, a repeat fee will now be chargeable regardless of the number of attempts the student has taken as access to services and teaching will be available. A standard exam fee will apply for students who repeat without attendance and this will be a 10 credit value of the programme. This fee is not eligible for student finance support for home students in receipt of funding and will be chargeable and payable by the student in full within 30 days of invoice.
f) Sections 4.1(a) - 4.1(e) inclusive apply to any student commencing their studies outside the main September/October entry point and their tuition fee liability will be calculated with reference to the dates of the teaching period relevant to that course of study.

4.2 For Postgraduate Taught Students On Campus

a) A student will not be liable to pay tuition fees if the student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy within the initial period.
b) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period one (but after the initial period has passed) and within the initial period of teaching period two, the student will be responsible to pay one third per cent (33%) of the full tuition fee for the academic year.
c) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period two (but after the initial period has passed) and within the initial period of teaching period three, the student will be responsible to pay two thirds per cent (66%) of the full tuition fee for the academic year.

d) If a student makes an application for withdrawal or leave of absence in accordance with this Policy in teaching period three (but after the initial period has passed), the student will be responsible to pay the full tuition fee (100%) for the academic year.
e) Sections 4.2(a)-4.2(d) inclusive apply to any student commencing their studies outside the main September/October entry point and their tuition fee liability will be calculated with reference to the dates of the teaching period relevant to that course of study.

4.3 Student Loan Company Information (Home Students ONLY)

a) If the student has taken a tuition fee loan from the Student Loans Company Limited (SLC) to pay their tuition fees, then Aston University will notify the SLC of any change in the student's circumstances and their revised tuition fee liability for that academic cycle. Students must also contact the SLC themselves to confirm this information.
b) Students who have been assessed to receive maintenance support for living costs and / or supplementary funding from the SLC may be asked to repay part of this funding if they withdraw or take leave of absence. The SLC will calculate on a pro rata basis the level of funding a student is entitled to receive.
c) If you are transferring from another institution to Aston University within 4 weeks of your course start date, then you will be charged for the full tuition fee. If you have left your previous institution, they will have the right to retain some or all of the fees due from you or your student loan and you will be liable for 100% of the University tuition fee due at the time of transfer.

4.4 Postgraduate Research and Postgraduate Taught Distance Learning students

a) Other than in the circumstances set out in section 4.4(b), a student's tuition fee will be recalculated where a student has made an application to be withdrawn from their programme or take leave of absence part way through an academic year. The student will be liable to pay tuition fees for the number of full calendar months that they have completed and any calendar months that they have partially completed. The recalculated fee is the full fee divided by 12 calendar months multiplied by the number of full calendar months and part calendar months completed on the programme. For example, a leave of absence from 15 January to 22 February will mean that the student is still liable to pay tuition fees for January and February, because the student will have partially completed those months of study.
b) Where a writing-up student withdraws from their programme or takes leave of absence, the writing-up fee will not be adjusted, and the student will continue to be liable to pay the full writing-up fee.
c) Where a continuation fee is payable by the student and a student withdraws from their programme or takes leave of absence, the continuation fee will not be adjusted. The student will continue to be liable to pay the full continuation fee. Where a student submits prior to their expected end date they will continue to be liable to pay the full continuation fee.

4.5 Pre-sessional English Programmes

Where a student withdraws from their programme or takes leave of absence part way through their programme, their tuition fees liability will only be reviewed if the reason for withdrawal or leave of absence is beyond the control of the student as identified in section 6 (Refunds).

4.6 Modular Learning (courses commencing prior to July 2024)

Where a student's application to be withdrawn from their module or take leave of absence is approved prior to the "withdrawal deadline," as identified in the Aston Online Learning - Academic Calendar and/or the offer letter the student will not be liable to pay the full fee, and a full refund will be granted. Where a student's application to be withdrawn or take leave of absence is not approved before the "withdrawal deadline" then the student may be liable to pay up to the full fee.

4.7 Aston Online Students

a) Undergraduate:

- Students paying with a government loan will follow the same liability that the Student Loan Company has set out for part time students - the Initial Period is 2 weeks (14 days) from the first day you are granted access to the digital campus. Tuition fees are then due in three instalments of 25%/25%/50%. No deposit payment will be required but confirmation of application and the SSN number will need to be provided within a reasonable period of time and prior to the course start date.
- Self-funded students will pay a £1000 deposit in advance of the start date. After the Initial Period has expired the deposit is no longer refundable. The Initial Period for levels 4 to 6 inclusive is 4 weeks (28 days) After the initial period has expired students will be liable to pay for 120 credits corresponding to their level of study.

b) Postgraduate:

- Students will pay a £1,000 deposit in advance of the start date. The Initial Period for modules 1 – 3 of the programme is 4 weeks (28 days) starting from the first day of teaching in week 1 of module 1. After the Initial Period has expired the deposit is no longer refundable and students will be liable for fifty per cent (50%) of the total programme tuition fee (i.e. one hundred per cent (100%) of the tuition fees for modules 1, 2 and 3). The Initial Period for modules 4 – 6 of the programme is 4 weeks (28 days) from the first day of teaching in week 1 of module 4. After the Initial Period has expired, students will be liable for the remaining fifty per cent (50%) of the programme tuition fee (i.e., one hundred per cent (100%) of the tuition fees for modules 4, 5 and 6).

4.8 Tuition Fees – General

The University believes that it is in the interests of both the student (or student's sponsor), and the University, that applicants and students should be notified as early as possible of the total fees due for their programme of study, including any additional costs, along with the arrangements for payment.

For each programme of study, the University will set, publish, and charge tuition fees for the full duration of that programme.

Tuition fees will be confirmed in the Offer letter sent to students.

5. DEPOSITS

The University must comply with the following requirements in relation to deposits.

5.1 Calculation of a deposit

Where an applicant is required to pay a deposit to secure a place on their programme, the amount of the deposit will be deducted from the total tuition fee payable for the academic year. If a deposit is required, it will be specified in your offer letter. Overseas students may also be requested to pay a per cent of fees in advance of enrolment. This will be specified in your offer letter.

6. REFUNDS

The University will comply with the principles below when processing refunds.

6.1 Deposit Refund

The University will refund the applicant the amount of the deposit payable to the student in accordance with this Policy without undue delay. The University will refund using the same means of payment as the applicant used for the initial transaction, and to the same account, unless the applicant and the University have expressly agreed otherwise. In such cases, the University is required to request additional evidence which may cause delay in processing the refund and may result in refusal to refund. In any event, the University is not responsible for bank changes or currency exchange losses incurred by the applicant because of the refund.

The University will not refund any deposit where there is found to be evidence of fraud or deception as part of the application and enrolment process.

6.2 Cancellation by students other than Aston Online Students

Students who are not Aston Online Students have a legal right of cancellation as set out in the student's offer letter (the cancellation period). If a student cancels acceptance of their place within the cancellation period, the University will refund any deposit paid. If a student cancels acceptance of their place outside the cancellation period, the University will not normally refund the deposit paid other than in the following circumstances:

- the requirements for the conditional offer have not been met by the applicant. Evidence will be required to prove that a genuine attempt had been made to meet the conditional offer.
- where the applicant is an overseas student and the application for entry clearance is refused (documentary evidence of refusal will be required). No refund will apply where entry clearance is refused due to submission of fraudulent documents/deception or any act of omission by the applicant in connection with such visa application; and
- in cases of exceptional extenuating circumstances (documentary evidence will be required). Please refer to section 6.7 for further information.

Any refund approved will be subject to retention of a £500 administration cost.

6.3 Cancellation by Aston Online Students

If an Aston Online Student cancels acceptance of their place within the cancellation period (as set out in the student's offer letter) or within the Initial Period (see paragraph 4.7 above), the University will refund any deposit paid.

If an Aston Online Student cancels acceptance of their place outside the cancellation period or outside of the Initial Period (see paragraph 4.7), the University will not normally refund the deposit paid other than in the following circumstances:

- the requirements for the conditional offer have not been met by the applicant. Evidence will be required to prove that a genuine attempt had been made to meet the conditional offer.
- in cases of exceptional extenuating circumstances (documentary evidence will be required). Please refer to section 6.4 for further information.

Any refund approved will be subject to retention of a £50 administration cost.

6.4 Tuition Fee Refund

Where a student has paid their fees in advance and subsequently applies to withdraw or take leave of absence, any refund will be calculated in accordance with this Policy. Payment of any refund will be made using the same means of payment as the applicant used for the initial transaction, and to the same account, unless the applicant and the University have expressly agreed otherwise. In such cases, the University is required to request additional evidence which may cause delay in processing the refund and may result in refusal to refund. Applications for a refund must be made by the student through MAP and will be processed within 28 calendar days after approval of the request by their college of study.

Aston Online students must make an application for a refund via e mail to enquiries@studyonline.com

The University will not refund any tuition fee payments where there is found to be evidence of fraud or deception.

6.5 Agency Fee Refund

Any refunds made will not include a refund of any agency fee paid by the applicant to an agent.

6.6 Student Visa Holders

To be eligible for a refund, Student visa holders must also provide the following to the Visa Compliance Team:

1. Evidence of return flight tickets
2. Proof of exit stamp from the UK, or re-entry stamp to the returning country that matches the flight tickets
3. Visa Compliance will complete an Immigration History Check to confirm that no further visa applications have been made to remain in the UK

Refunds will not be issued if the student has made an in-country application to switch visa categories, or if points 1 and 2 are not met.

6.7 Extenuating Circumstances Relating Specifically To Deposits And Tuition Fee Refunds

The University shall consider each case of extenuating circumstances on a case-by-case basis. Please be aware that academic and financial difficulties are not normally regarded as acceptable reasons for any refund. Such cases must be submitted to the Academic Registrar (or their nominee). The following table sets out an indicative and non-exhaustive list of extenuating circumstances that are acceptable and non-acceptable to the University.

Circumstances accepted by the University	
	Notes
1. Recent (< 1 month) death or serious illness of a close relative	"Close" means parents & guardians, children and siblings, and a spouse/partner. It may include in-laws, grandparents, and grandchildren if it can be shown that the relationship was close, but not usually aunts, uncles, or cousins.
2. Recent (< 1 month) diagnosed illness or serious accident of the student	Illness or accident affecting study that is an incapacitating illness or an unexpected deterioration in an ongoing illness or medical condition which includes bone fractures and serious sprains. Medical certification must be obtained, and medical evidence must bear the GP's practice stamp and/or be on appropriate headed paper.
3. Recent (< 1 month) change of employment circumstances	Unforeseen changes in employment, for example: withdrawal of sponsorship by an employer (letter from employer must be provided). loss of employment removing the ability to progress with the course financially (letter from employer must be provided).
4. Recent (< 1 month) other unforeseen significant circumstances	Political unrest, natural disaster, national emergency.
Circumstances not accepted by the University	
	Notes
Minor ailments and other conditions	Minor ailments where symptoms may be relieved by over-the counter medication, sprains, long-standing medical conditions for which special arrangements could have been made or treatment anticipated and taken. Accidents/illness affecting relatives or friends (unless serious or the student is the sole carer).
Social	Difficulty integrating to university life or home sickness or a decision to commence with employment rather than academia.
Non-serious domestic or personal disruptions which could have been anticipated	Moving house, holidays, weddings, religious festivals, or other events where the student either has control over the date or may choose not to participate. Change of job or "normal" job pressure (exceptional crises at work might be acceptable). Illness or death of pets.
Study-related	Decision to transfer to an alternative institution, computer difficulties, late distribution of materials by the College, delays in printing, photocopying and issues with predefined timetabling of modules.

7. NON-PAYMENT

Please refer to Section 3.5 of the Debt Management Procedures for Students for a detailed outline of the process the University will initiate should a student fail to meet a payment point, namely restricted access to digital services through the application of sanctions.

8. COMPLAINTS

Students should refer to the University's published Student Complaints Procedure if they wish to make a complaint in relation to any matter addressed under this Policy.

Aston University
Birmingham
B4 7ET, UK

+44 (0)121 204 3000
aston.ac.uk

UNIVERSITY OF THE YEAR 2020 The Guardian

POSITIVE ABOUT DISABLED PEOPLE

Race Equality Charter
RACE CHARTER